

Why do AI use our drinking water instead of other sources?

Posted by u/Snoo-42199 • 0 points • 15 comments

I just learnt that AI uses water and I thought it wouldn't be a huge issue because there's plenty of water on earth from the ocean. Turns out, AI actually uses drinking water and that's why people are mad about it, including me now. Why do AI uses drinking water instead of other sources that are infinite?

Comments

u/archpaw • 1 points • 2025-06-09 10:11 UTC

Water is used in generating electricity, and I think some datacenters use evaporative cooling. If you used seawater, it would leave a bunch of salt behind. It might be possible to do that, but it's not worth it for the utterly trivial amount of water it uses. From what I can find, ChatGPT took roughly ten cows' worth of water to train.

u/TehNolz • 2 points • 2025-06-09 10:06 UTC

It's because the alternatives are more expensive. Yeah, we could technically cool servers using sea water and the like, but that stuff tends to contain a lot of salt so your equipment is going to start rusting much faster. So while getting the water would be cheaper, the maintenance costs would skyrocket, and it ends up being more expensive overall. And since companies don't like spending money, they're almost always going to pick the cheaper option rather than the ethical one.

u/generic_redditor_71 • 1 points • 2025-06-09 10:06 UTC

You can't use salt water in a cooling tower. It leaves behind salt when it evaporates, which would instantly clog everything. Even the trace mineral content in fresh water needs management in cooling towers, and it's a tiny fraction of what's in saltwater.

u/lreeb • 1 points • 2025-06-09 09:56 UTC

They contribute to water consumption indirectly by consuming a lot of electricity - many power plant types, including nuclear and coal, heat water to run their turbines.

Apart from that, data centers often use water to cool their components. Salt water or dirty water could corrode and clog up the cooling systems.

u/Snoo-42199 • 1 points • 2025-06-09 10:04 UTC

Why don't they just filter out the water so they can use it?

u/ParagonProtocol_94 • 1 points • 2025-06-09 09:56 UTC

The data centres used to power AI use water to help cool them, and drinkable water may be used to do so also, but theres nothing to suggest that they exclusively use drinkable water in the cooling process.

u/chococaliber • 0 points • 2025-06-09 09:55 UTC

Bro is full on drug psychosis AI is using our drinking water instead of not drinking water

u/kaiservvv3 • 1 points • 2025-06-09 09:53 UTC

Because salt water has to be filtered and must be used around stainless steal so it's more expensive to build the cooling system and do the maintenance. In other words, the reason is greed.

u/Procks_ • 2 points • 2025-06-09 09:52 UTC

What the fuck are you on about

u/Snoo-42199 • 0 points • 2025-06-09 10:00 UTC

Why does AI need to use our drinking water?

u/YodasChick-O-Stick • 1 points • 2025-06-09 09:51 UTC

Can you elaborate on how exactly AI uses water at all?

u/Snoo-42199 • 0 points • 2025-06-09 09:58 UTC

AI uses water to cool down the data centre. Instead of using recycled water they use our drinking water

u/YodasChick-O-Stick • 1 points • 2025-06-09 18:33 UTC

So AI uses drinking water for cooling, and Reddit doesn't? Or any other website?

u/ForScale • 2 points • 2025-06-09 09:50 UTC

AI is not stealing your drinking water.

u/Snoo-42199 • -1 points • 2025-06-09 09:56 UTC

It does

u/ForScale • 0 points • 2025-06-09 10:06 UTC

No lol